

Horton Creek Field Brief

Finding Zora — Episode 01 · Overnight, Sat May 2 → Sun May 3, 2026

Quick Reference

Trailhead	Derrick Trailhead (alt. access — Horton TH closed through Dec 31, 2026)
From Chandler Hts	I-10 / Loop 202 → Beeline Hwy 87 N to Payson → AZ-260 E ~16 mi → left on FR 289 at Kohl's Ranch / Mile 268 → ~1 mi to Derrick lot on left. Drive ≈ 2 hr.
Coordinates	Approx. 34.336°N, 111.097°W
Cell service	None at trailhead or in canyon. Download offline maps before Payson.
Sunrise (Sun May 3)	5:33 AM MST · First light 5:08 AM · Sunset Sat 7:00 PM · Last light 7:25 PM
Payson Ranger Dist.	(928) 474-7900 — call Fri to confirm Horton Spring camping closure status
After-hours / fire	(480) 457-1555
Emergency	911
Live closure map	usfs.maps.arcgis.com / apps / instant / basic / index.html?appid=4ef3d1bad1d541dea8b7cd52ad7fa613

Itinerary

Saturday May 2

11:00 AM	Depart Chandler Heights
1:00 PM	Through Payson — last fuel, top off water, final cell signal
1:45 PM	Arrive Derrick TH. Photograph kiosk closure map. Gear check.
2:15 PM	Hike connector → old Horton TH → start Trail #285 north
4:00-4:30 PM	Arrive camp zone (target: 1.5-2 mi up, near the waterfalls)
5:00-7:00 PM	Set camp · golden-hour scout & B-roll · pre-rig sunrise position
7:00 PM	Sunset · dinner · gear prep for 4:30 wake

Sunday May 3

4:30 AM	Wake. Coffee, gear up, headlamps.
5:00 AM	In position at chosen pool / cascade. Camera live, audio rolling.
5:08 AM	First light — watch for alpenglow on rim wall if visible from your spot
5:33 AM	Official sunrise — primary mist + first-light shoot
6:30 AM	Wrap shoot, walk back to camp
7:00 AM	Eat, break camp, leave-no-trace check
7:30 AM	Hike out down Trail #285
8:30 AM	At vehicle. Reception returns near Payson.
9:00 AM	Roll on FR 289
11:30 AM-12 PM	Home for lunch

Route & Camp Strategy

Simple out-and-back. From Derrick lot, walk the connector (~300 yards) over to where Horton Creek Trail #285 starts at the old Horton TH, then head north along the creek. Skip the Derrick→Highline loop entirely — there isn't time with an afternoon arrival, and you don't need to be that high for the shot.

Camp zone target

- **1.5–2.0 miles** up Trail #285 from old Horton TH. Prettiest section of the canyon, well below any spring closure, light elevation gain (~400 ft) so you arrive with energy.
- Look for previously-used flats **set back at least 200 ft from water**, on the west side where the trail rides higher above the creek.
- **Position with the morning shot in mind:** pick a flat within 100 yds of an open pool or cascade with east-ish sky visibility. The waterfalls section near the 1.2-mi mark is your best bet — there are several pools with morning sky exposure.

Closure check on arrival

- Photograph the trailhead kiosk. Whatever's posted is binding.
- Mexican spotted owl seasonal nesting closure (Mar–Aug) likely active around the spring. Stay below it; you're not going up there anyway.

Sunrise Shot Plan

Primary: mist on the creek (5:08–6:00 AM)

From your camp pool, position low and across-current. Snowmelt is running so the water is cold; with overnight low ≈ mid-30s the temperature differential will produce thick mist at first light. Capture the cold blue of pre-sunrise (5:08 AM), then the warm raking light through the pines as the sun crests (5:33 AM). Shoot wide for B-roll, then tight for hero pool shots. Long exposure on the cascade once you have enough ambient light.

Bonus: rim alpenglow

If your camp position has direct sightline north to the rim cliff face, the Coconino Sandstone wall lights up orange/pink for ~10–15 min before the sun reaches you. This is a bonus, not the main shot — scout for the sightline when you set camp. If you have it, swing the camera north between mist takes.

Audio capture

- Get clean ambient at 5:00 AM before any wind picks up. Pines + water + raven calls = your primary ambient bed.
- If bringing a horn, the canyon walls return sound surprisingly well. Recorder a few yards off-axis works better than at-source.

Wildlife & Features Watchlist

Almost guaranteed	Mule deer, Steller's jay, acorn woodpecker, common raven, white-breasted nuthatch. Possibly elk near dawn meadow openings.
Likely	Black bear sign (scat, torn logs, claw marks on aspen), wild turkey, pine siskin, German brown trout in deeper pools.
Possible / lucky	Peregrine falcon (rim cliffs), Mexican spotted owl (cliff face — do NOT approach if nesting), Arizona black rattler (rocky/creekside as it warms).
Plant features	Ponderosa pine (smell the bark — vanilla butterscotch), bigtooth maple, Gambel oak, quaking aspen leafing out, fern + moss colonies.
Geology	Coconino Sandstone cliff (Permian dunes ~275 mil yrs), Kaibab Limestone cap, spring emerges where porous sandstone meets impermeable layer.

Narration / Story Beats

L.J. Horton — the namesake

Cattle rancher, settled here in the 1880s. Built the wagon road that became Trail #285. Lost his entire herd to rustlers shortly after settling — never ranched again. Wrote his memoirs about the Pleasant Valley War while living at the Arizona Pioneer Home in Prescott; archived at Sharlot Hall Museum.

The spring as system

Snowmelt and rain on top of the rim percolates through porous Coconino Sandstone (windblown dunes from ~275 million years ago), hits an impermeable layer, and shoots horizontally out the cliff face. Horton Spring runs year-round, thousands of gallons per hour. Bear, Knoll, and Canyon Lakes drain into this aquifer system.

The vanishing creek

Horton runs strong near the spring, then disappears into the limestone bed on its way to Tonto Creek, then re-emerges. From the Tonto confluence it looks like a dry wash — most visitors miss it. Good metaphor; good B-roll if you film both states.

Highline Trail history

Established ~1870 to connect homesteads along the rim base. Zane Grey and Babe Haught used it on hunting expeditions. Grey's cabin stood ~3 mi east of your route until the 1990 Dude Fire destroyed it (same fire killed 6 firefighters).

2024 Horton Fire

Recent fire scar visible in parts of the drainage. Aspens regenerating aggressively from existing root networks — neon-green new growth in spring.

Hazards & Reminders

- **Lightning:** Mogollon Rim has the 2nd-highest lightning incidence in the U.S. Off exposed terrain by noon if storms forecast (less of an issue in early May).
- **Water:** Untreated water = giardia. Filter or boil. Plan 1 gal/person/day.
- **Bear:** Hang food 100 ft from sleep area, 10+ ft up. No scented gear in tent.
- **Snake:** AZ black rattler observed on this trail. Watch hands/feet on rocks and creek edges as morning warms.
- **Cold:** May overnight at ~5,800 ft can drop to mid-30s. Pack layers + warm bag, especially if camping near water.
- **Cell:** None. Tell Jennifer route + return time + hard 'call SAR' deadline before leaving Payson.

Pre-Departure (Friday night / Saturday AM)

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|---|--|
| ☐ Call Payson RD (928) 474-7900 — closure status | ☐ Charge gimbal + camera batteries (x2) |
| ☐ Check Tonto NF live closure map | ☐ SD cards formatted, spares packed |
| ☐ Check fire restrictions for weekend | ☐ Tell Jennifer route + return time |
| ☐ Check 24/48 hr weather forecast | ☐ Set hard 'call SAR' deadline |
| ☐ Download offline map (Gaia/CalTopo) | ☐ Top off water bottles night before |
| ☐ Charge S25 Ultra + power bank | ☐ Vehicle: fuel + spare jug |
| ☐ Charge audio recorder + spare batteries | ☐ Bear hang line / Ursack / canister |

On Arrival at Trailhead

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| ☐ Photograph kiosk closure map | ☐ Send 'going dark' text to Jennifer |
| ☐ Note any new postings / fire orders | ☐ Lock vehicle, valuables out of sight |
| ☐ Read MSO signage if posted | ☐ Time-stamp opening B-roll |
| ☐ Final cell-service check | |

Filming Priorities

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| ☐ Cold open: closed Horton TH reveal | ☐ Golden-hour creek pools (Sat PM) | ☐ Wildlife — whatever shows up |
| ☐ Drive-in B-roll · FR 289 · kiosk | ☐ Sunrise — mist on creek (Sun AM) | ☐ Narration cutaways at scenic stops |
| ☐ Connector + first creek glimpse | ☐ Bonus — rim alpenglow if visible | ☐ Closing piece-to-camera at exit |
| ☐ Camp setup time-lapse | ☐ Waterfall at 1.2 mi (long exposure) | ☐ Acoustic ambient: dawn (no wind) |

Compiled for Tank · Finding Zora Ep. 01. Field-verify everything before you commit. Conditions, closures, and trail status change without notice.